

BACKGROUND GUIDE (AIPPM)

**AGENDA: “One Nation, One Election
(ONOE): Evaluating the feasibility, impact
on governance, and democratic
implications of simultaneous elections
while balancing federalism.”**

i. Preface

The process of election is the corner-stone of any democratic system; it's a device to determine the authority for governance of the country for a defined period. Free and fair elections are heart and soul of the representative form of government and serve as means of communication between the public and the government. Electoral reforms have been an issue of intense debate in contemporary India, particularly in the last one decade. The time has come for us to look at the electoral reforms for improving the system and ensuring free and just elections and better representation of the popular will. Today the problems of greatest interest in connection with elections are frequent elections, requirement of vast election machinery, huge cost and time invested for elections, suspension of development activities due to MCC, regulation of expenditure, registration of voters and election abuses. To streamline the electoral system and procedure, radical reforms are needed. The frequent elections in one or the other part of the country are imposing huge burden on human resources and adversely impacting the economy and development.

The government has accepted the recommendations of High-Level Committee under Chairmanship of Shri Ram Nath Kovind, Former President to hold synchronized elections in the country. This Theme Paper on 'One Nation, One Election' discusses the subtleties of holding simultaneous elections. The paper also brings forth the constitutional and legal provisions for elections, national and international experiences on concurrent elections, the views expressed by various committees on it; and the benefits and challenges of having simultaneous elections.

ii. LETTER FROM THE EXECUTIVE BOARD

The Executive Board hopes that this background guide helped you by serving as the foundation of your research, as it was intended to. Reiterating the aforementioned, this Background Guide is only the starting point of your research and not an exhaustive document. Since the topic is vast and profoundly linked with the history of India, the Executive Board recommends all participants to delve deep into the agenda, explore political stances, legal and social aspects, case studies etc. Ensure that you make all efforts to maintain the required decorum and adhere to the rules of procedure of the simulation when in session.

iii. VALID SOURCES

- .Government Reports (Each ministry publishes its own reports including External Affairs Ministry)
- PTI , PIB
- Government Websites
- Government run News channels i.e. RSTV, LSTV, DD News
- Standing Committee Reports/ Commission Reports
- RTI Proofs
- Parliamentary Standing Committee reports
- Questions and Answers of the parliament
- Other sources as suggested by the Executive Board(Judges)

iv. IMPORTANT SUB - AGENDAS

- Maintaining federalism while promoting good governance
- Reduce the influence of national issues in local elections
- Solutions: Voting systems, such as proportional representation, a two-round system (runoff voting), instant-runoff voting, Instant Round Robin Voting called Condorcet Voting, citizen initiatives and referendums and recall elections among others.
- Vote-counting procedures
- Rules about political parties, characteristically changes to election laws
- Eligibility to vote
- How candidates and political parties are able to stand (nomination rules) and how they are able to get their names onto ballots (ballot access)
- Electoral constituencies and election district borders
- Ballot design and voting equipment
- Scrutineering/ scrutinizing (election monitoring by candidates, political parties, etc.)
- Safety of voters and election workers
- Measures against bribery, coercion, and conflicts of interest
- Financing of candidates' and referendum campaigns
- Factors which affect the rate of voter participation

IMPORTANT COMMISSIONS

- Jaya Prakash Narayan Committee
- Dinesh Goswami Committee
- Jeevan Reddy Committee
- Indrajit Gupta Committee
- Vohra Committee
- Election Commission Reports

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****** Sections 5, 6, 7, 8, and 15 are supplementary and included to enhance clarity and reduce research effort. Refer to them if you seek deeper insights and stronger points for your speech.

1. INTRODUCTION TO AIPPM

The All India Political Parties Meet (AIPPM) serves as a forum for representatives of various political parties to engage in discussions on pressing national issues. Unlike conventional parliamentary proceedings, AIPPM operates as informal deliberative bodies where leaders from different ideological spectrums articulate their views, negotiate positions, and strive for consensus on policy matters. This committee replicates real-world political dynamics, encouraging delegates to represent their party's stance effectively while engaging in constructive debate.

AIPPM is unique as it fosters a platform where national and regional interests converge, requiring delegates to balance political commitments with pragmatic governance solutions. The discussions in this committee shape legislative perspectives, influence policy decisions, and contribute to the broader democratic discourse in India.

2. METHOD OF RESEARCH

To effectively participate in this AIPPM session, delegates must conduct thorough research across various dimensions of the topic with the help of this Background Guide as well as their own. Below are the key research methods:

1. Pre-Research Preparation

- Before beginning the research, **thoroughly review the entire Background Guide** to get an overview of the agenda, section titles, and key themes.
- Identify the **core objectives** of the study and understand the broader context of elections, governance, and federalism.
- Establish **personal guidelines and benchmarks** for speech preparation, documentation, and structuring arguments effectively. That is, be prepared with answers and questions of all types.

2. Understanding the Concept and Historical Background

- Study the **Electoral Reforms** in India and past instances of simultaneous elections (1952, 1957, 1962, and 1967).
- Review reports by the **Election Commission of India (ECI)**, **Law Commission (170th and 79th Reports)**, and **NITI Aayog** on the feasibility of the policy.
- Analyze the reasons why simultaneous elections were discontinued in 1967.

3. Examining Legal and Constitutional Aspects

- Read relevant provisions in the **Indian Constitution** (Articles 324–329 related to elections).
- Review Supreme Court judgments and **constitutional amendments** required for implementation.
- Analyze debates around the **federal structure** and potential conflicts with **State Autonomy**.

4. Evaluating Governance and Political Impact

- Research how frequent elections impact **policy continuity, administrative efficiency, and fiscal expenditure**.
- Study the advantages and disadvantages of simultaneous elections on **governance stability, federalism, and voter behavior**.
- Analyze case studies from other democratic countries (e.g., the USA, Germany) that follow synchronized election cycles.

5. Party Positions and Political Perspectives

- Try to understand not only your allotted portfolio/party stand on the topic but also of other parties in order to be prepared better.
- Study the official **manifestos and statements** of major political parties (BJP, Congress, regional parties, etc.) regarding One Nation, One Election.
- Understand how regional parties and state governments perceive the move as **centralization of power vs. efficiency in governance**.
- Examine how coalition politics and opposition strategies shape the debate.

6. Media Reports and Expert Opinions

- Follow **news articles, opinion pieces, and editorials** from sources like The Hindu, The Indian Gazzete, PRS India, and ORF. and other authentic and primary sources (avoid secondary sources),
- Refer to expert analyses from political scientists, legal scholars, and think tanks like the **Centre for Policy Research (CPR)** .
- Watch panel discussions and debates on news channels/YouTube for diverse perspectives.

7. Public Opinion and Surveys

- Refer to **public surveys, election studies, and voter behavior analysis** to gauge citizen support or opposition to simultaneous elections.
- Study past electoral trends and the impact of staggered vs. synchronized elections on voter turnout and political engagement.

8. Research Documentation and Review

- At the end of each research segment, **take imperative notes** on key takeaways and core issues related to the study.
- Revisit and clarify any **missed portions** by recollecting them and cross-referencing with primary sources.
- After completing all research, prepare an **End-of-Research Document**, **summarizing main points** from each studied article.
- Read the **Background Guide twice** to ensure maximum understanding and enhance mental recall before drafting position papers and speeches.

By following this structured research approach, delegates can develop well-informed arguments, anticipate counterpoints, and engage in insightful discussions on the feasibility and implications of **One Nation, One Election**.

3. Statement to the Problem: ‘One Nation, One Election’

a. INTRODUCTION

The idea of ‘One Nation, One Election’ deals with conducting simultaneous elections for the Lok Sabha and the state assemblies once in five years. This will involve the restructuring of the Indian election cycle in a manner that the state and central elections synchronize.

The idea of simultaneous elections is not new to the country. The general elections of 1951-52, 1957, 1962, and 1967 were held simultaneously for both the Parliament and the state assemblies. However, the cycle was disrupted by political upheavals which led to midterm elections for Kerala and Odisha in 1960 and 1961 respectively (Panda 2016). This was followed by several disruptions caused partly due to lack of a clear mandate or the mid-term collapse of a government and by the frequent use of Article 356 and Article 352, which extended the elections. Over the years, several Lok Sabhas and State Assemblies have been prematurely dissolved. As a result, the cycle of simultaneous elections has been disrupted.

"Democracy' and 'free and fair election' are inseparable. Elections are the centerpiece of democracy; it is difficult to visualize democracy without elections. Ensuring free and fair elections is the first prerequisite for the success of democratic process. Elections are a very vital part of the political process which emanates from the fundamental assumption that people are sovereign. In any democracy, the people do want and have every right to change governments according to their wishes, in a peaceful and orderly manner. The little man, in his multitude, making his vote at the poll does a social audit of his Parliament plus political choice of his proxy. Elections give the executive and legislative branches the representative nature they need to reflect the will of the people. The most powerful aspect of democracy unquestionably is the highest number of individuals participating in elections.

India, a Socialist, Secular, Democratic Republic, is the largest democracy in the World. The modern Indian, which came into existence on 15th of August 1947, is a constitutional democracy with a parliamentary system of government. Democracy is one of the inalienable features of the

Constitution of India and forms of its basic structure. The concept of democracy as visualised by the Constitution presupposes the representation of the people in Parliament and state legislatures by the method of election. At the heart of the system lies a commitment to hold regular, free and fair elections.

Federal democracies, which are frequently distinguished by the coexistence of national and subnational governmental levels, face a unique challenge-frequency of elections. In the past decades, India is also grappling with the same issue with hundreds of state assembly elections taking place. These frequent elections come at a high cost in terms of money and administrative work and also causing inconvenience to citizens, political parties and government. This has triggered a debate for adoption of 'One Nation, One Election' – simultaneous elections. On September 18, 2024, the Union Cabinet, chaired by the Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, accepted the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Simultaneous Elections under the chairmanship of former President Shri Ram Nath Kovind.

A Constitution has to be a 'living document' that is capable of adapting to changing needs and requirements of people and society. It has to be dynamic, effective and efficient, responding to the changing situations and growing needs of the citizens and meeting their expectations. However, at the same time the intrinsic values and basic features of the Constitution, such as democracy, free and fair elections and federalism cannot be compromised. In this background we need to examine and to implement the 'one nation, one election' rule; introducing reforms in the domain of the electoral system without damaging the intrinsic character and framework of the Constitution. No doubt it is not an easy task; there will always be people who will view the changes with doubt and oppose them, and want the status quo to be continued throughout.

b. Simultaneous Elections – Meaning and Scope

Federal democracies, which are frequently distinguished by the coexistence of national and subnational governmental levels, face a unique challenge-frequency of elections. In the past decades, India is also grappling with the same issue with hundreds of state assembly elections taking place. These frequent elections come at a high cost in terms of money and administrative work and also causing inconvenience to citizens, political parties and government. This has triggered a debate for adoption of ‘One Nation, One Election’ – simultaneous elections.

There is no specific definition of the term simultaneous election. Several terminological definitions of Simultaneous General Elections have been provided by experts. Sugato Dasgupta et al., describe “Simultaneous General Elections as General Elections that are held at the same time for several types of elections at once”.⁷¹ Shugart presents a refined opinion. According to him, “Simultaneous General Elections are general elections conducted at the same time to elect office holders at the national and regional levels, related to parliamentary candidates and presidential candidates for countries with a presidential system of government”.⁷² On basis of these definitions, it can be concluded that simultaneous general elections contain several different elections at once, both different in scope and positions filled.⁷³

c. Models of Simultaneous General Elections

There is no uniform model for Simultaneous elections. Schakel and Dandoy based on their research among European countries, sampled countries which generally use parliamentary system of government, discovered the trends in the form of simultaneous elections conducted in the European region.⁷⁴ These trends have been grouped into six types of simultaneous election models, which are as follows:

(i) National, Provincial, and District/City simultaneity

In this model, all types of elections, both at the national and regional (provincial and district/city) levels, in a country are conducted simultaneously on the same day. These elections cover all levels, from the national to the regional level, both provincial and district/city. If the country adheres to the Presidential System of Government, the election of

Candidates for Members of the House of Representatives as power holders and Candidates for President - Vice President are conducted simultaneously. There are no other elections.

(ii) National and provincial simultaneity

In this concurrent model, elections in all provinces are conducted simultaneously with national elections on the same polling day. However, the elections at district level are conducted separately.

(iii) Provincial and district/city simultaneity

This simultaneous model focuses on organizing regional-level elections, simultaneously nationally. This simultaneous means that all general elections at the regional level (both provinces and district/city) are held on the same day. Meanwhile, general elections at the national level are held at different time, separate from general elections at the regional level.

(iv) Provincial simultaneity

In this model, all elections at the provincial level, both the election of legislative candidates and candidates for governor as the holder of executive power, are conducted simultaneously at the national level. In this model, elections at the national level as well as at the district/city level are conducted on other election days.

(v) Regency/City simultaneity

In this Model, simultaneity is only found in General Elections at the Regency /City level. The elections are held simultaneously for all regencies/cities in a province only. This model has implications for the implementation of different general elections in each province. Also, the timing of implementing general elections at the national and provincial levels is different.

(vi) Another simultaneity

Using a sample of EU member states, the Simultaneous Elections model is intended to classify countries that conduct elections for the President and Members of the EU Parliament on the same election day. Furthermore, the model is also used to classify countries that hold referendums simultaneously on the same day.

Besides, the studies which examined the models of simultaneous elections applicable in countries in Europe that generally adhere to the parliamentary

system, there are also studies on models of simultaneous elections, which are compiled based on the results of research on countries in the Americas, including Latin America which generally use a presidential system of government. According to Syamsuddin Haris et al., models of simultaneous general elections consist of several types, among others.⁷⁵

(i) National, Provincial, and District/City simultaneity

In this model of election, all elections are held at the same time. These elections cover all levels, from the national to the regional level, both provincial and district/city. Besides, the elections target more than just elections to fill the positions of members of parliament or heads of government. The elections include all holders of executive and legislative power.

(ii) Branches of Power Simultaneity

There are two stages of elections in this simultaneous model- general elections to fill the legislative branch of power and general elections to fill the executive branch of power. First legislative elections at the national and regional (provincial and district/city) levels would be held. The executive elections to elect the President as head of government at the national level along with regional heads across the country would be held sometime later simultaneously.

(iii) Levels of Government Simultaneity

The implementation of general elections is divided based on the level of government of a country in this simultaneous model. General elections are divided into two types: national general elections and regional general elections. Elections for members of the national parliament and the President are conducted simultaneously in national elections. Whereas, elections for regional heads and regional parliamentarians are conducted in regional elections.

(iv) Time Interval Based Simultaneity

In principle, this model of simultaneous elections is the same as the model based on simultaneous levels of government. However, there are important differences between the two regarding implementation time. In the simultaneous general election model of the concurrent levels of government, regional-level elections are conducted simultaneously in all regions. Meanwhile, this simultaneous model does not require the implementation of

Regional-level elections at one time only. Regional-level elections will be conducted periodically, such as in different islands or provinces, according to their geographical location. For example, the National General Election will be held in 2023, followed by the Regional General Election in 2024 for provinces located on Island A and the Regional General Election in 2024 for provinces located on Island B. With this kind of simultaneous model, general elections will continue to exist yearly.

(v) Flexible Provincial Simultaneity

The simultaneous election model is the same as the time interval-based simultaneous model. This model allows each provincial-level region to have different or the same general election time. This condition can occur because the simultaneity of local-level elections only covers the territory of a province. Provinces have the freedom/autonomy to determine when elections will be held in their provinces to elect members of parliament and regional heads, both at the provincial and district/city levels.

(vi) Legislative and Executive National Simultaneity

Unlike the previous models of simultaneous elections, which were structured based on levels of government and the division of branches of power, this model combines both. This model will elect members of parliament, both at the national and regional levels (provincial and district/city), simultaneously with the election of the President as the holder of executive power at the national level. Meanwhile, regional head elections are conducted simultaneously in all country regions.

4. Perspectives of Political Parties

- **Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP):** Supports ONOE, citing governance stability, economic benefits, and efficiency.
- **Indian National Congress (INC):** Expresses concerns over federalism, autonomy of states, and logistical challenges.
- **Regional Parties (TMC, DMK, SP, AAP, BJD, etc.):** Generally oppose, fearing marginalization and loss of state-specific electoral narratives.
- **Left Parties:** Highlight the potential impact on democratic diversity and pluralism.
- **Election Commission & Judiciary:** Emphasize constitutional amendments, legal safeguards, and the need for political consensus.

5. Concurrent Elections-Country Specific Experience

(i) South Africa

In South Africa, national and provincial elections are held every five years. The electoral system for Parliament and Provincial assemblies is based on “proportional representation and party lists”. Before the election, each political party provides a list of candidates arranged in numbered order of preference. The seats of Parliament are allocated in proportion to the number of votes cast in the election. This means a party that won 10% of the votes gets 10% of the seats. If a party wins 20 seats, the first 20 people on its party list become MPs.⁷⁶ The Independent Electoral Commission (IEC) established under the IEC Act, 1996 decides how many people from each party-list should take up seats in the legislatures. For Municipal Councils also elections are held after every five years though not along with National and Provincial elections. there is a “mixed-member system” in which, wards elect individual councillors alongside those named from party-lists.

(ii) Sweden

Sweden is a parliamentary democracy, there are no presidential elections in Sweden, only parliamentary elections. Sweden follows the proportional electoral system. The political parties are assigned number of seats in the elected assembly based on their share of votes. In their system elections for the Parliament (Riksdag), County Councils and Municipal Councils all take place at the same time. These elections occur every four years on the second Sunday of September whereas elections to the Municipal Assemblies occur on the second Sunday of September, once every five years. After an election, the Election Authority distributes the seats proportionally, depending on the number of votes that each party has received.⁷⁷

(iii) Belgium

In Belgium, one can vote in five different elections:

- European elections: representatives for the European Parliament;
- Federal elections: for the federal parliament (the Chamber of Representatives);

- Regional elections: for the legislative bodies of the federated regions, e.g.: the Flemish Parliament, the Walloon Parliament, the Parliament of the Brussels Capital Region, the Parliament of the German-speaking Community;
- Provincial elections: for the Provincial council; and
- Municipal elections: for the Municipal council.

Elections for the Federal Parliament are normally held every five years, coinciding with the European (and consequently also regional) elections. The German Parliament can propose a resolution to remove the government only if it names a successor.

(iv) Indonesia

The Constitutional Court of Indonesia, while reviewing Law No. 42 Year 2008 concerning Presidential Elections, vide decision No.14/PUU-XI/2013, held that Indonesia will hold the presidential elections and legislative elections concurrently starting 2019, on the ground that Law No.42 of 2008 was contrary to the constitutional provision. For India, Indonesia is a living laboratory to study the One-Nation, One-Election system, though their electorate is only about a quarter of India's. On 14th February, 2024, Indonesia successfully conducted simultaneous elections, being termed as the world's largest single day elections; wherein Indonesians chose a new president and vice president, a parliament, and lawmakers among 20,000 administrative posts across the country. Each voter on five ballot papers chose their preferred presidential and vice-presidential pairing, lawmakers at the national, provincial, and regency level, and a regional senator to advise the national parliament.

(i) Germany

German model of 'constructive no-confidence' stipulates that the unseating of a government must immediately be followed by the formation of a new one, which will serve out the remainder of the legislative term. Under the provisions of Basic Law of Germany, the only option for the Bundestag is to express its disapproval for the Government leader, by passing the motion containing the name of his successor (Art.67). This should be supported by majority of Deputies. If the motion is passed successfully then the Cabinet has to resign.

Simultaneous elections, in one form or the other, do exist in various parts of the world. Countries like Philippines, Brazil, Bolivia, Columbia, Costa Rica, Guatemala, Guyana, Honduras, Nicaragua et al, follow a system of

simultaneous elections. However, these countries follow Presidential form of Government and the election of President and the elections to the Legislative are held together.

(i) Philippines

The Philippines has a Presidential form of government. The country follows a system of simultaneous elections, by virtue of an Act passed in 1992 that paved the way for synchronized elections. In Philippines national and local elections are held simultaneously since 1995. Simultaneous elections are held for national and local officials at an interval of every three years. Section 3 of the 1992 Act specified that the term of President, Vice President, and Senators will be six years. Out of the twenty-four Senators elected in May 1992, the first twelve with the highest number of votes will serve for six years, and that the remaining twelve will serve for three years. Members of the House of Representatives and all elective provincial, city, and Municipal officials once elected will serve for a term of three years. Section 4 of the Act provides for full synchronisation of elections for President and Vice President on the second Monday of May and on the same day every six years thereafter. For the senators, all members of the House of Representatives and Municipal Officials, elections are held on the second Monday of May and on the same day every three years thereafter.

6. Simultaneous Election –Indian Scenario

India, the world's largest democracy, has over 968 million eligible voters. The country holds elections for multiple tiers of government, including the Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha, state legislative assemblies, and local bodies. The foundation of India's electoral system is rooted in its Constitution, which outlines a federal structure, clearly dividing powers between the central and state governments. Over time, several high-level committees have reviewed potential electoral reforms such as public funding of elections, the right to recall legislators, and transitioning from the first-past-the-post system to proportional representation. Among these, the 'One Nation, One Election' proposal, which seeks to synchronize the election cycles of central and state governments, has sparked the most debate, aiming to streamline governance and reduce the cost and frequency of elections.

On September 18, 2024, the Union Cabinet, chaired by the Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi, accepted the recommendations of the High-Level Committee on Simultaneous Elections under the chairmanship of former President Shri Ram Nath Kovind.⁷⁸ The simultaneous elections will be implemented in two phases. In first phase the elections to Lok Sabha and Assembly will be conducted simultaneously. In the second phase, the elections of the local body elections (panchayat and municipalities) will be conducted within 100 days of general elections. To implement the concurrent elections, common electoral roll for all elections will be prepared. The government will initiate detailed discussions throughout the country and also constitute an implementation group. The government proposes to bring three Bills in Parliament to implement simultaneous election. Out of these, two Bills include amending the Constitution to put in place the government's plan to hold simultaneous elections for the Lok Sabha, state assemblies and local bodies in a phased manner.⁷⁹

In common parlance, "simultaneous elections" means conducting elections simultaneously for all three tiers of the constitutional institutions: the House of the People (Lok Sabha), State Assemblies (Vidhan Sabha), and local

bodies. This essentially means that votes are cast on the same day to elect representatives at all three tier of government.⁸⁰

Debates surrounding electoral expenditure, particularly the costs incurred in deploying personnel and the extended duration of the Model Code of Conduct, are critical in shaping the discourse on electoral reforms in India. The frequent conduct of elections not only adds financial strain but also amplifies caste, religious, and communal tensions, influencing social cohesion. These concerns fuel discussions on the feasibility of the ‘One Nation, One Election’ proposal, which seeks to reduce the frequency and associated challenges of conducting separate elections. In this document, we will explore these issues in detail, examining their implications for electoral efficiency and national unity.

The number of institutions at the third tier of governance is too large. As of April 2024, there are around 2.63 lakh panchayats in India.⁸¹ The conduct of election to these institutions is a State subject. According to the Constitution, the elections to the third tier institutions are controlled and organized by their respective State Election Commissions. Therefore, synchronizing and aligning election schedules of all three tiers is difficult. Therefore, what ‘One Nation, One Elections’ contemplate is that that the elections of the House of the People and State Legislative Assemblies are conducted simultaneously—all electorates will vote in Lok Sabha and Assembly elections—to elect central and state representatives, in the same year, if not at the same time.

The Indian general elections 2024 were held by the Election Commission over the period April-June 2024 to constitute the 18th Lok Sabha. Along with elections to the Lok Sabha, elections for constituting the State Assemblies of only 3 states were held, which were Andhra Pradesh, Sikkim, and Odisha. The rest of the states followed a non-synched five-year cycle. Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Telangana, were among those voting at different times in the previous year, 2023. Haryana voted on October 5, 2024. The Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir also held its first Assembly election after 10 years during September-October, 2024. Jharkhand, and Maharashtra will go for elections later this year. These elections to State Assemblies were announced within two months of concluding the Lok Sabha elections and elections to other State Assemblies. India is going for elections every six months, may it be state assemblies, elections to the third tier of Government (Panchayati Raj institutions /

Municipal bodies), bye-elections, etc. The result is that the number of elections in any given year would substantially increase, putting a lot of pressure on resources. Regular elections have a detrimental effect on overall governing process and the administrative and development initiatives. Therefore, various stakeholders have expressed an urgent need to develop a mechanism to put an end to these recurrent election cycles. One potential solution being examined is holding simultaneous elections.

On examining the history of elections in India, one finds that general elections for the House of the People and State Legislative Assemblies were conducted simultaneously during the first two decades after independence, i.e., in the years 1951–1952, 1957, 1962, and 1967. During the first general elections held between October 1951 and May 1952, a three-tiered process was followed for electing the President and Vice-President, members of the Lower Houses at the Centre and in the States, and members of the Upper Houses. The main reason behind the synchronized elections till then was the dominance and rule by one national political party and the regional parties were not powerful and influential. The indiscriminate use of Article 356 of the Constitution also contributed to disruptions of simultaneous elections.

The Report on the Second General Elections in India, 1957 states:

*"If the House of the People and the different State Legislative Assemblies were all allowed to complete their respective terms in full, the General elections to reconstitute them would have had to be held at different points of time. In such a case, it would not have been possible to hold simultaneous country-wide general elections, both for the House of the People and the State Legislative Assemblies. It was therefore, decided that the second general elections should be completed before the end of March, 1957, and that the existing Houses of Legislature should be dissolved prematurely, whenever necessary, in order that the newly elected Houses might meet soon after the general elections were over."*⁸²

In furtherance of this decision, seven State Legislative Assemblies Bihar, Bombay, Madras, Mysore, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal were dissolved prematurely. The decision to dissolve the Houses by the Election Commission of India was reached through consensual approach in consultation with all political parties, the Central Government and the State Governments. For the same the Election Commission called a conference of the All-India Political Parties in New Delhi on the 13th November, 1956.⁸³ The concurrent elections offered convenience for both the voters and the

authorities responsible for the conduct of elections. Political parties and their candidates were also benefited.

7. HISTORICAL CONTEXT

The First Four General Elections after Independence-Brief

(i) 1951-52 - First General Elections in Independent India

The first general elections in independent India, under the Constitution of the India, were held in 1951-52. It certainly was the largest election ever held, "the biggest experiment in democracy in human history".⁸⁴ India took the decision to introduce universal suffrage in a country where 85 percent of the adult population was illiterate and poor; no less than 176 million persons were eligible to vote. Being the first elections in the independent India, it was expected that a large majority of them will go to the polls and most of them had never voted before. The elections were held for about 4500 seats in the House of the People in the Parliament and the State Legislative Assemblies, that too concurrently. Seven hundred million ballot papers were printed. Approximately 224,000 polling booths were constructed and equipped with over two million steel ballot boxes for smooth conduct of elections. Some 56,000 Presiding Officers for polling booths were required who were assisted by 280,000 clerks and 224,000 policemen. Atleast two million people actively participated in the conduct of the elections, either as officials or as political workers. The cost of conducting the elections for the central and state governments alone was estimated at more than \$20 million;⁸⁵ the costs to the parties and candidates combined were even larger.

Being the first election for a country, which has undergone partition resulting in population transfer of unprecedented magnitude accompanied by devastating communal violence, the registration procedure for elections itself was a herculean task. Preparation of electoral rolls was even more tedious and difficult for India as compared to any other country because of the illiteracy of many citizens and thus the great difficulty was of getting names recorded properly. In addition, the large number of refugees in the country made necessary the special rule⁸⁶ that only persons of 21 years of age or older on March 1, 1950 who have lived for at least 180 days in a constituency between April 1, 1947 and December 31, 1949 would have a right to vote in that constituency. Though the effect of this rule was to eliminate a moderate number of persons from the electoral rolls; but without such a rule, those compiling the official lists would have faced with the impossible job of deciding the formal residence of a shifting population.

Almost three million, refused to give their own names to the registration officers. They chose to be enrolled simply as wives or daughters, using the name of a male relative for the purpose of registration. The Election Commission ruled these registrations off the records; hoping that when the electoral rolls were revised in 1952 these women would understand the necessity for all citizens, regardless of sex, to take an individual part in the process of elections.

In the delimitation process, the constituencies for the House of the People were demarcated on contiguous-area basis, bearing in mind the constitutional provision that the population in each constituency shall range between 500,000 and 750,000. For this election, the number of persons per constituency was around 720,000. Thus in single-member constituencies each member of the House of the People represented over 700,000 persons. In the House of the People and in most of the State Legislative Assemblies, some seats were reserved for the Scheduled Tribes and the Scheduled Castes as per Constitutional mandate.

The Election Commission Report on the First General Elections⁸⁷ states “The conduct of elections in as large a country as India, among a still mainly illiterate population, where transport and communication are frequently difficult, is a very great administrative task.” According to Richard Leonard Park⁸⁸, the 1951-52 general elections were experimental in nature. The electorate was enormous and politically inexperienced, and there are few precedents to guide observers. Nevertheless, the Government of India, the Election Commission, and the organized political parties of India earnestly attempted to make their first general election a fair and fruitful experiment in the development of a democratic India.

(ii) Second General Elections in 1957

The second national elections⁸⁹ since independence in India were held this year 1957 from February 24 to March 14. In these elections, over 115 million voters (nearly 60 percent of the 193 million eligible) casted their ballots for 488 members of Lok Sabha and for 2,901 members of the Vidhan Sabhas of 13 state assemblies, and for councils in two Union Territories. The elections were contested by over 50 political parties and an uncounted number of independents- according to one of the estimate, the total running for office at more than 14,000. Most of these parties were of local, and frequently temporary. Only 15 parties were given official recognition by the Election Commission. Four of these were recognized as "national" parties:

Congress, Praja-Socialist, Communist, and Jana Sangh. The remaining were recognized as "state" parties. During this election some 200,000 polling station operated throughout the country, and the election was completed in less than three weeks and the results were announced by April 1. Indelible ink, 2,875,000 steel, tamper-proof ballot boxes, over 500 million ballot papers were used in the second general election.

(iii) 1962- Third General Elections

Nearly 114,000,000 voters took part in India's third general elections since independence which took place in February 1962.⁹⁰ Through these elections a new parliament was elected along with thirteen state assemblies.

(iv) Fourth General Elections in 1967

The changes in the political scenario could be sensed after the fourth General Elections held in 1967.⁹¹ The dominance which the Congress Party had maintained for 20 years was broken. The key leaders including the party president, Shri K. Kamaraj, were defeated. In eight states (governing two-thirds of the Indian population) non-Congress governments were formed. Congress seats in the Lok Sabha dropped from 73.1% to 54.6%- with a loss of 81 seats. In elections to the Lok Sabha the Swatantra and Jana Sangh parties made striking gains in number of seats (from 18 and 12 in 1962 to 44 and 35 in 1967, respectively) with a relatively small increase in percentage of the popular vote.

The election witnessed the rise of stronger non-Congress parties and new party coalitions at the national as well as at the state level. If we examine 1967 elections in relation to 1962 elections, there are certain obvious phenomena which are visible. Firstly, there was allegiance and loyalty for both Congress and non-Congress partisans. Secondly, there was defection of 1962 voters/supporters from Congress to non-Congress parties and vice versa. On one hand the disinterest and withdrawal of 1962 voters was visible and on the other the involvement of new voters, both those eligible to vote in 1962 but who stayed home, and those eligible for the first time in 1967 could be seen. These changes in political dynamics in 1967 paved ways for prospective changes and probabilities of major political realignment in the future. In the 1967 elections, predominant movement was consistently away from Congress. If one compares the Lok Sabha -and state assembly votes which switched to Congress and away from Congress-the proportions are 29% to 71% against Congress. But the votes which switched away from

Congress were so evenly distributed among the Right, the Left and the other parties that the disadvantage to Congress in gross terms was minimized.

The following are some of the aspects which emerged during the fourth general elections which not only changed the national political scenario but also resulted in elections becoming asynchronised afterwards:

The Congress monolith, which for so long has dominated the Indian political landscape, has been badly cracked, but not shattered.⁹² The one party dominance, was no longer an accurate description of the party structure. Further the one party dominance was not succeeded by a two-party or three-party or multiple-party system, but rather, by "a cross-party polity of dubious value."⁹³ Even though in the fourth general elections Congress still emerged as the most important party; but this time its losses in seats in the Lok Sabha and the State Assemblies was even greater than the marked decline in its popular vote. On the fourth general elections, Eric da Costa, Director of the Indian Institute of Public Opinion, wrote:

The Indian electorate, believed inert and incapable of dramatic choice, is showing signs of a revolutionary change. The young, the less educated, and particularly illiterates, the minorities and, most unpredictable of all, the lowest income groups are all rewriting their basic loyalties. To the candidates this is, perhaps, a struggle for power. To a political scientist it is, as nearly half a century ago, the beginning of a break with the past.⁹⁴

The Congress failed to tackle grave national problems vigorously and to put its own house in order. It could not identify itself more realistically with the felt needs and aspirations of an increasingly conscious and increasingly demanding Indian electorate. After nearly twenty years of rule, it seemed vulnerable on many counts for its real or alleged sins of omission and commission.⁹⁵ Besides this, for most of the voter and in most constituencies, the main issues during that period were local, or at most regional. The really great issues confronting the nation, relating to the survival of India as a democratic state, economic development, national security, foreign policy, seemed hardly to figure at all. The political map of India was seemingly transformed, and the Congress for the first time seemed to be cracking up. This was not so much because of a nationwide revulsion against it; but because of more effective opposition tactics in which representatives of many different parties and groups, of many different ideological predilections and practical interests, participated. However, the voters did not give any clear

indication of their alternate preferences, except in certain local and State situations.⁹⁶ The elections "have produced a mixed bag altogether. It is amply clear that the electorate does not want the Congress. It is not very clear what it does want."⁹⁷ The 1967 elections was thus beginning of emergence of regional and local parties, which later had influence on the national politics and elections.

However, with the passage of time, the concurrent nature of elections was lost due to dissolution of the elected bodies before the expiry of their maximum duration of five years. The cycle of simultaneous elections was broken up by the dissolution of several state assemblies in 1968 and 1969, the dissolution of the House of the People (4th Lok Sabha) in 1970, and the general elections that followed in 1971. The term of Fifth Lok Sabha was extended till 1977 due to declaration of emergency under Article 352. The Eighth, Tenth, Fourteenth, and Fifteenth Lok Sabha could complete their full five year terms; whereas the terms of the Sixth, Seventh, Ninth, Eleventh, Twelfth, and Thirteenth Lok Sabha were shortened due to premature dissolution. Similar problems regarding period of time were also faced by various State Assemblies. With the change in Indian political scenario, the regional political parties not only increased in number, but also registered their presence in the elections to the concerned State Assemblies.

In the present scenario, atleast one part of the country is witnessing an election throughout any given year. These premature dissolutions and extension interrupted the cycle of simultaneous elections. This resulted in burden in terms of time, energy and money on the voters, political parties and their leaders and the election authorities. Consequently, the country is continuously in an election mode. This highlights the need for simultaneous elections as against the fragmented and staggered election cycle prevalent currently.

8.PRESENT SCENARIO

Recommendations of Various Committees on Simultaneous Elections

(i) The Franchise Committee Report of 1932

The Franchise Committee Report of 1932⁹⁸, looking into franchise issues, suggested that the franchise for the Assembly should be the same as for the provincial councils as it involved the preparation of only one electoral roll.

“There is also the complication that it is the present practice to hold elections both for the provincial councils and for the Legislative Assembly on the same

days. This arrangement has been devised partly to meet the convenience of voters who often have to travel considerable distances to the poll, and partly to avoid a double stoppage of ordinary administrative activity. It also suits candidates and political parties. But if there were to be adult franchise both for the provincial and for the federal legislatures, it would be necessary either to have a polling machinery which could deal at the same time with about 130 million electors, each entitled to cast votes for two different constituencies and candidates, or to duplicate the whole process at different times.'⁹⁹

The Franchise Committee Report of 1932, therefore, clearly provides a historical background for the concept of simultaneous elections and underlines the efficiency, convenience and coherence attainable through synchronized electoral cycles.

(ii) Election Commission of India First Annual Report in 1983

Election Commission in its first Annual Report in 1983¹⁰⁰, supported the notion of conducting concurrent elections for both the House of the People and the State Legislative Assemblies. Seven compelling reasons for holding simultaneous elections to the House of the People and State Legislative Assemblies were expounded which are as follows:

- a) *Considerable savings on the colossal avoidable administrative and other expenditure incurred on account of holding of separate general elections, (Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies).*
- b) *Substantial economy through revision of electoral rolls for the House of the People and the State Legislative Assemblies simultaneously instead of undertaking them on a countrywide basis twice over in two different operations.*
- c) *For the conduct of elections, civilian personnel running into about twenty-five lakh officers and staff and a few lakh police personnel are deployed every time for about two to three months, seriously affecting their normal duties.*
- d) *During elections, whether for the Lok Sabha or the assemblies, the entire administrative set up throughout the country slows down considerably and all other normal functions and activities of the Government, including developmental work, are pushed to the background. These create a lot of hardships and sufferings to the common man. The situation continues for*

about two months during the conduct of every general election (Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies).

- e) *Whereas changes in the administrative set up including transfers that become necessary in the normal course are not permitted under the broad guidelines issued by the Election Commission, there are considerable pressures prior to the issue of the notification calling for a general election to make wholesale changes, particularly at the district level.*
- f) *On account of the de-linking of the general elections to the House of the People from that of the State Legislative Assemblies, there is a duplication of the expenditure incurred by the candidates contesting elections and political parties, which results in the pumping in of considerable resources that indirectly affects money supply in the economy. Further, by such delinking, the candidates for parliamentary elections need more money and resources to fight the election singlehanded over a wide area without the backing and co-operation of companion candidates of the assembly segments. This also, it is suspected, tends to lead to difficulties for candidates to keep within the ceiling for election expenses.*

(iii) National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution (NCRWC) Report, 2002

The National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution, headed by Shri Justice M.N. Venkatachalaiah in its Report, 2002¹⁰¹ also recognized the need to restore simultaneous elections.

(iv) Parliamentary Standing Committee Report (2015)

The Standing Committee on Personnel, Public Grievances, Law and Justice under Chairmanship of Dr. E.M. Sudarsana Natchiappan made a systematic study of the matters involved in holding of elections in 2015. The Committee submitted its report on 'Feasibility of Holding Simultaneous Elections to House of People (Lok Sabha) and State Legislative Assemblies' on December 17, 2015. The committee emphasized on need for holding simultaneous elections. The Committee noted that the holding of simultaneous elections to Lok Sabha and state assemblies would reduce: (i) the massive expenditure that is currently incurred for the conduct of separate elections; (ii) the policy paralysis that results from the imposition of the Model Code of Conduct during election time; and (iii) impact on delivery of essential services and (iv) burden on crucial manpower that is deployed during election time.¹⁰²

(v) Law Commission Reports recommending Simultaneous Elections

The Law Commission of India from time to time has deliberated on number of issues related to the conduct of elections. In its reports of 1999, 2015 and 2018 (draft), the Commission has recommended the adoption of the practice of simultaneous elections to reduce the encumbrances of asynchronous elections on citizens, political parties and government authorities.

(a) 170th Law Commission Report (1999)

The Law Commission under the Chairmanship of Justice B P Jeevan Reddy, submitted its 170th Report in May 1999. The Commission had stated:

*“This cycle of elections every year, and in the out of season, should be put an end to. We must go back to the situation where the elections to Lok Sabha and all the Legislative Assemblies are held at once. It is true that we cannot conceive or provide for all the situations and eventualities that may arise whether on account of the use of article 356 (which of course has come down substantially after the decision of Supreme Court in S.R. Bommai v. Union of India) or for other reasons, yet the holding of a separate election to a Legislative Assembly should be an exception and not the rule. The rule ought to be ‘one election once in five years for Lok Sabha and all the Legislative Assemblies’ ”.*¹⁰³

(b) 180th Draft report of the Law Commission, 2018

The Law Commission of India under the Chairmanship of Justice B.S. Chauhan was called upon to study the issue regarding holding of simultaneous elections to the House of the People and the State Legislative Assemblies by Department of Legal Affairs. The Commission examined legal and constitutional questions related to the conduct of simultaneous elections. The 180th draft report of the Commission on “Simultaneous Elections” was released on August 30, 2018. Some of the significant recommendations made by the Commission in the draft report are as follows:¹⁰⁴

- **The Commission observed that simultaneous elections will be beneficial and will: (i) save public funds; (ii) lessen the strain on the administrative setup and security forces; (iii) ensure the timely implementation of government policies; and (iv) make sure that the administrative machinery is working on development projects rather than campaigning.**

- **Need for changes in constitutional and legal framework for conducting simultaneous elections:** The Commission stated that simultaneous elections are not permissible within the existing framework of the Constitution. Appropriate amendments to the Constitution, the Representation of the People Act of 1951, and the Rules of Procedure of the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies, will be needed to facilitate simultaneous elections to the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. Additionally, the Commission recommended that the constitutional amendments are required to be ratified by at least 50% of the states.
- **Framework for synchronisation of elections:** The Commission suggested three options to synchronise elections in India. These were:
 - **Option 1-** The Commission suggested advancing or delaying some state elections so that the Lok Sabha and all state assemblies might have elections at the same time in 2019. It mentioned that, in addition to the Lok Sabha elections, five states—Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Odisha, Sikkim, and Telangana—are scheduled to hold elections in 2019. It suggested the following adjustments be made to other state assemblies' election schedules:
 - **Assembly elections scheduled before Lok Sabha elections:** Elections for four states—Mizoram, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, and Chhattisgarh—are scheduled for late 2018 or early January 2019. By amending the Constitution, the duration of these legislatures may be increased to coincide with Lok Sabha elections.
 - **Assembly elections scheduled immediately after Lok Sabha elections:** If there is political agreement, elections to four legislatures (Haryana, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, and Delhi) may be held in conjunction with Lok Sabha elections, if the states dissolve their assembly willingly beforehand, or by operation of law.
 - **Assembly elections in remaining states:** Elections to the remaining 16 states and Puducherry might take place by the end of 2021. These assemblies will have term for 30 months, or till June 2024, whichever comes first. This will necessitate a constitutional amendment in order to either shorten or lengthen the terms of the several assemblies.

- Subsequently, elections to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies might then take place concurrently starting in 2024.
- **Option 2:** If assembly elections are held in 2019 and 2021, as previously mentioned, it will only be necessary to hold elections twice every five years.
- **Option 3:** If simultaneous elections are not possible, then the Commission suggested that all elections that are scheduled in a given calendar year be held concurrently. The timing of such election should be conducive to all state legislatures involved and the Lok Sabha (if dissolved earlier). The Constitution and the Representation of the People Act, 1951 both will need to be amended in order to implement this option.
- **No-confidence motion:** The Commission pointed out that if a resolution of no confidence is passed, the term of the state assembly or Lok Sabha may be curtailed. It suggested making the necessary changes to convert the "no-confidence motion" into a "constructive vote of no-confidence." In a constructive vote of no confidence, the current government may be overthrown only if there is confidence in a different government. It also suggested limiting the number of such motions during the term of the House or Assembly.
- **Hung House/ Assembly:** In case of hung House/ Assembly, where no party gets absolute majority to form the government, the Commission recommended that the President/ Governor should give a chance to the largest party along with their pre or post-poll coalition partners to form the government. If the government cannot still be formed, the impasse may be resolved by calling an all-party meeting. If this doesn't work, midterm elections might be held. The Commission suggested making the necessary amendments to ensure that any new Lok Sabha or Assembly established following midterm elections would only be constituted for the remaining period of the previous term, not the full five years.
- **Amendment to anti-defection laws:** The Commission suggested that suitable amendments be made to anti-defection laws to ensure that all disqualification issues resulting from defection are decided by the presiding officer within six months.

(vi) Working paper by NITI Aayog, 2017

NITI Aayog Working paper on “Analysis of Simultaneous Elections: the What, Why and How” 2017 deliberated upon the proposal to conduct elections to the House of the People and the State Legislative Assembly, simultaneously analyzing the existing constitutional provisions, financial and logistical implications related to it. It indicated the desirability of holding simultaneous elections on more than one account.

(vi) Report of the six-member High-Level Committee under the Chairmanship of Shri Ram Nath Kovind, Former President, 2024

In September 2023, the Union Government constituted six-member High-Level Committee under the Chairmanship of Shri Ram Nath Kovind, Former President to "examine and make recommendations for holding simultaneous elections" in the Lok Sabha, State assemblies, and local bodies. The panel was assigned with the task of suggesting specific amendments to the Constitution and any other legal changes necessary to enable simultaneous elections and other related aspects. Major suggestions and recommendations made by the Committee are as follows: ¹⁰⁵

- The Committee has recommended that simultaneous election be held in the country. The committee has observed that a climate of uncertainty is created by regular elections. The simultaneous elections will provide stability and predictability in governance by reducing disruption and policy paralysis. Simultaneous election will boost turnout while cutting expenses. Also holding elections at the same time promotes better government spending, more investments, slower inflation, and faster economic growth.
- The Committee suggested a framework for concurrent elections, which necessitates for suitable amendments to the Constitution. All state assemblies and municipal bodies should be dissolved as a one-time action, regardless of the remaining term, at the time of the next Lok Sabha election. This will harmonize all elections. The Committee suggested simultaneously holding elections for the Lok Sabha, all State Assemblies, and local bodies within 100 days from then.
- The amendments should provide for designating an ‘Appointed date’ (being the day of the first meeting of the newly constituted House of the People) after which the conduct of elections to the State

Legislative Assemblies (for the constitution of the State Legislative Assemblies) will take place. The tenure of all such Houses will expire with the tenure of the House of the People. For the constitution of the new Houses, the Election Commission of India will conduct simultaneous elections for the House of the People and the State Legislative Assemblies together. Where any State Legislative Assembly is dissolved on account of no-confidence motion, a hung House, or any other event, fresh elections will be held for such new House with its tenure ending with that of the House of the People.

- The Committee has recommended that for the purpose of making synchronised elections effective, a Constitution Amendment Bill shall be introduced in the Parliament amending Article 83 (Duration of Houses of Parliament) and Article 172 (Duration of State Legislatures) of the Constitution. This Constitution Amendment will not need ratification by the States. Another Constitution Amendment Bill will be introduced for insertion of Article 324A for elections to Municipalities and Panchayats, passed with ratification by the states.
- Thus the Committee observed that ratification by the states will not be required for constitutional amendments pertaining to the term of state assemblies and Parliament. However, constitutional amendments in relation to local bodies must be ratified by at least half of the states.
- The committee also suggested the way out in case there is a hung assembly. A legislature is elected for a five-year term. Therefore, if there is a hung legislature at any point of time, they would be out of sync for the following simultaneous election. The Committee suggested holding new elections for a hung legislature or local body with a reduced term in order to remedy this. For the simultaneous election, the shortened term will be equal to the remaining portion of the five-year cycle.
- The committee opined that there is need for Single electoral roll. Two constitutional authorities -Election Commission of India and State Election Commissions- supervise election process. Election Commission of India (ECI) for both Houses of Parliament, State

Legislative Assemblies and Councils, President, and Vice-President; and State Election Commissions (SECs) for local entities. Preparation of electoral roll by SECs is administered by respective state laws. Some state laws permit SECs to prepare separate electoral rolls, while others allow them to use the electoral roll prepared by ECI.

- This will lessen redundancy and duplication across multiple agencies. The Committee suggested that ECI shall be the authority to create the unified electoral roll after consulting with SECs. An amendment to the Constitution will be needed to implement single electoral roll. The Committee also observed that the constitutional amendments in this regard are required to be ratified by atleast half of the states in order to become effective.
- The Committee recommended that ECI and SECs need to undertake planning and estimation for logistical arrangements around the time of the rollout.

9. Need for Simultaneous Elections

(i) MCC Slows down the pace of Development

Frequent imposition of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) causes policy paralysis and slows down the pace of the developmental programmes. The Model Code of conduct comes into operation from the date of announcement of election schedule by the Election Commission and remains operative till the process of elections is completed. During Lok Sabha elections, the code is applicable throughout the country and during elections to the Vidhan sabha, in the entire State. While the model code is in effect and applicable in the designated area, only routine governmental activities can be carried out and development initiatives, welfare schemes, capital projects, and other initiatives are essentially put on hold.

Though it is alleged that the MCC comes into play only from the date of announcement of elections; however, political parties in power start their preparation much before and come out with various populist measures to ensure their win in the elections.

During general elections in India, the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) is enforced across the country to ensure free and fair elections. In the most recent Lok Sabha elections 2024, the MCC remained in effect for 82 days.¹⁰⁶

During this period, several implications arise for the government. Primarily, governance-related activities and policy decisions are restricted, particularly those that could influence voter behaviour. Development projects, welfare schemes, and appointments are often paused, which can delay essential public services. Additionally, the government is barred from launching new schemes or making significant announcements, impacting both the pace and scope of governance during the election period. When considering separate elections for the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, the repeated enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) at both national and state levels poses significant challenges to governance. Each time elections are held in different states, the MCC is enforced, leading to frequent pauses in governmental decision-making and project implementation. This disruption hinders the delivery of public goods and services, as governments are restricted from initiating new policies or continuing key development projects. The repetitive enforcement of the MCC not only affects governance efficiency but also slows down the overall progress of public welfare initiatives across states.

According to data from the Election Commission of India, the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) was in force for a total of 676 days between 2019 and 2024, covering both Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. (Table 1) This implies that, on average, India spends approximately 113 days each year under the MCC. In a country with a population of 1.5 billion, the restriction of development and welfare activities for such a significant portion of the year raises serious concerns. This recurring pause in governance and policy implementation presents a challenge for ensuring consistent development and service delivery, thereby warranting further examination of its broader socio-economic implications.

Table 1

Enforcement of Model Code of Conduct Each Year in India										
2019		2020		2021		2022		2023		2024
Jharkhand	50 days	Bihar	42 days	Assam	64 days	Goa	51 days	Meghalaya	43 days	Lok Sabha
Haryana	30 days	NCT of Delhi	30 days	Kerala		Manipur		Nagaland		Andhra Pradesh
Maharashtra				Puducherry		Punjab		Tripura		Arunachal Pradesh
Lok Sabha	71 days			Tamil Nadu		Uttarakhand		Chhattisgarh	54 days	Odisha
Andhra Pradesh				West Bengal		Uttar Pradesh		Madhya Pradesh		Sikkim
Arunachal Pradesh						Gujarat	36 days	Mizoram		Jammu & Kashmir
										52 days

Odisha						Himachal Pradesh	62 days	Rajasthan		Haryana	
Sikkim								Telangana			
Total	160 days	Total	72 days	Total	64 days	Total	149 days	Total	97 days	Total	134 days

Source: Election Commission of India

The Parliamentary Standing committee states:

*“The imposition of Model Code of Conduct (MCC) puts on hold the entire development programme and activities of the Union and State Governments in the poll bound State. It even affects the normal governance. Frequent elections lead to imposition of MCC over prolonged periods of time. This often leads to policy paralysis and governance deficit”.*¹⁰⁷

(ii) Cost Efficiency

The Election Commission is holding multiple elections every year. Conducting the elections in multiple phases results in a large amount of expenses for the country. In addition to the regular elections, a number of bye-elections are also conducted. This also places a significant strain on the government's finances. Frequent elections put extra financial strain on the government's exchequer. Each year, the Government of India and respective State Governments incur huge expenditure on organizing, managing, and overseeing elections. In addition to the government, political parties and candidates contesting elections also have to spend a lot of money and incur huge expenditures.

The candidates have to incur expenditure on various logistical needs to reaching out to the electorates. If the expenses of political parties are also added, the amount will increase further. While political parties spend money on running their electoral machinery during elections, arranging prominent leaders' campaigns, and other necessary activities; candidates typically incur expenses for traveling to their constituencies, general publicity, planning outreach events for voters, etc.

With regards to the expenditure incurred by candidates and political parties, the ECI vide Rule 90 of the Conduct of Election Rules, 1961 as amended on January 6, 2022 prescribes maximum limits for election expenditures by a candidate.¹⁰⁸ After the amendment, the present limit is Rs. 95 lakhs per candidate for a parliamentary constituency (i.e for elections to Lok Sabha) in larger states like UP, Bihar, Madhya Pradesh etc. This limit is Rs. 40 lakhs for an assembly constituency in the same States. However, there is no such limit prescribed for expenditure by political parties. In actual practice,

the candidates and political parties spend significantly more than the prescribed expenditure limits in their attempt to win elections. The compulsion to spend more is consequently blamed as one of the factors for corruption and black-money in the country.

According to the data provided by the Election Commission, expenditure on elections relates to: setting up of the polling stations and making necessary arrangements therein; payment of TA/DA etc. to polling personnel / counting staff; making transport arrangements for personnel involved in polling and counting duties; making infrastructure facilities at polling booths / counting centres; purchasing election material to be utilized for election; and other expenditures for smooth conduct of polling and counting.

Huge Expenditure incurred during Election is one of the major concern. Conducting elections on such a vast scale is an extremely difficult task for the Election Commission of India, requiring careful planning to safeguard the voting rights of the country's diverse electorate. The expenditure on organizing Lok Sabha elections has increased significantly over the years. For example, India's first general election in 1951-52, conducted over 68 phases, incurred a relatively modest expenditure of Rs 10.5 crore.¹⁰⁹ In contrast, the 2019 general election saw costs soar to Rs 50,000 crore (\$7 billion), as reported by the Centre for Media Studies.¹¹⁰ Based on these trends, the 2024 election is projected to nearly double this expenditure, potentially reaching Rs 1,00,000 crore.

In a vast country like India, with approximately 968 million voters, elections are a frequent occurrence. The expenditures for state assembly (Vidhan Sabha) elections are distinct and separate from those incurred during the Lok Sabha elections. For instance, during the Assembly elections in Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, and Uttarakhand in 2022, the total expenditure amounted to Rs 470 crore, a figure solely reflecting the spending by political parties.¹¹¹ (Table 2) The expenditure by the states themselves on these elections is significantly higher, further adding to the financial burden of the electoral process in India.(Table 3)

Table 2**Total Expenditure by Parties during Assembly Elections, 2022**

Mode of expenditure incurred	Total Expenditure incurred by political parties during Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh & Uttarakhand Assembly Elections, 2022 (in Rs Cr)						Total Expenditure
	Central Headquarters	State Units					
		Goa	Manipur	Punjab	Uttar Pradesh	Uttarakhand	
By Cash	0.1903	0.048	8.7260	0.152	0.1640	0.0017	9.282
By Cheque/DD	256.374	21.246	12.765	31.146	51.944	30.9726	404.448
Remaining unpaid	28.355	0.526	1.004	2.652	21.130	2.704	56.371
Total	284.92	21.82	22.495	33.95	73.238	33.678	470.101

Source- Association for Democratic Reforms

Table 3**Party wise expenditure during Assembly Elections, 2022**

Political Party	Total Expenditure incurred by political parties during Goa, Manipur, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh & Uttarakhand Assembly Elections, 2022 (in Rs Cr)						Total Expenditure (in Rs Cr)
	Central Headquarters	State Units					
		Goa	Manipur	Punjab	Uttar Pradesh	Uttarakhand	
BJP	86.374	13.986	11.402	18.063	66.784	26.539	223.148
INC	72.536	7.554	10.471	0.033	4.964	7.092	102.65
BSP	68.646	-	-	0	0	0	68.646
AITC	40.778	0	-	-	-	-	40.778
SAD	0	-	-	15.72	-	-	15.72
AAP	8.730	0.0344	-	0.0983	0.2778	0.026	9.167
NCP	5.28	0	0.054	-	-	-	5.334

RLD	1.6493				0.0135	0	1.663
AIMIM	0.0175				1.172	0	1.189
Shivsena	0.573	0.2458	0.0439		0		0.863
NPF	0		0.45				0.45
CPI	0.272		0.074	0.025	0.0072	0.0213	0.40
CPI(ML)(L)	0.064			0.011	0.019	0	0.094
Grand Total	284.92	21.82	22.495	33.95	73.238	33.678	470.101

(-) Did not contest in the State Assembly election

Source- Association for Democratic Reforms

Advocates of the 'One Nation, One Election' proposal argue that the separate expenditures on state assembly elections could be significantly reduced through simultaneous elections. They assert that political parties allocate approximately 35% of their budgets to campaigns and publicity, a cost that could be minimized if both Lok Sabha and assembly elections were held together.¹¹² This synchronization would eliminate the need for duplicating efforts in campaign management, voter outreach, and publicity at different times, thereby streamlining the electoral process and reducing overall expenditure for political parties and the state.

(iii) Causes hardship to citizens

Frequent elections cause disruption to normal life of citizens and effects the functioning of essential services. People face inconvenience due to disruption of road traffic and noise pollution due to holding of political rallies. Simultaneous elections can limit these disturbances to a certain pre-determined period of time. Frequent elections also result in uncertainty and instability, upsetting supply chains, business investments and economic growth.

(iv) Reduced Disruption to Governance

With continuing cycle of elections in one or the other part of the country, the political parties, including the ruling party at the Centre and the State(s), tend to invest their time and energy more on the elections, rather than on the governance, deviating attention from core issues of good governance and development, to campaigning for elections. Restricting the

elections to once in a five years' affair will help in dedicating time and resources towards development activities.

(v) Administrative efficiency

Regular deployment of government officials and security forces for elections hinders discharge of their duties. The crucial manpower which is often deployed for prolonged periods on election duties disrupts government machinery. The polling booths are mostly located in schools, whether Government or private. Engaging school staff and teaching personnel for election duties, compromises their primary duty of imparting education as schools remain closed even prior to elections. Similar is the situation with the employees of Central and State Governments and the PSUs who are assigned election duty.

The security forces are deployed normally throughout the elections and they remain mobile from one place to another. As one or the other state goes for elections every six months, the situation leads to security forces remaining locked in for prolonged period of time, taking away a big portion of such armed and police forces, which could otherwise be better deployed for other internal security purposes, which is their core function.

(vi) Increased Voter turnout

Further a number of studies have indicated that combining national and state elections could potentially increase voter-participation-a hallmark of representative democracy. Staggered elections induce 'voters' fatigue' and present a significant challenge in ensuring their participation. In simultaneous elections, citizens could vote for national and state elections simultaneously which could reduce voters' fatigue.

a. Challenges for 'One Nation, One Election'

Opponents of the idea say that simultaneous elections will compromise the federal nature of governance, weaken democratic diversity, and introduce administrative complexities that will far outweigh the benefits. They are of the opinion that neither the cost of elections nor the restrictions of the model code of conduct are determining concerns for holding concurrent elections. Elections every five years are undoubtedly less expensive than multiple elections held at various intervals; however with simultaneous elections the money saved will be less than Rs 5,000 crore annually. Should that be the deciding factor for an economy like India?¹¹³ Further they are of the opinion

that the restrictions of the model code of conduct will only apply for a limited period and its application is nationwide only when there's a national election. It's a minor concern at the state level. According to them, elections which are the most significant manifestation of democracy, shouldn't be judged based on their cost or by the conduct required for their fair implementation. The term of 17 state assemblies will be shortened to hold synchronized elections in 2029; this violates the basic structure of the Constitution. For violating the basic structure of the Constitution, the expenditure and consequential savings for conducting synchronized elections is being given as a justification.¹¹⁴

Arguing against 'One Nation, One Election' they opine that it contradicts the character of our country. When we do not have one religion, one language, one culture then why one elections. We're a union of states and the differences and diversity constitute our wealth which make us special and significant. Secondly, it also likely to lead to prioritizing national issues over local ones. They also suspect that it has a tendency to convert a federal structure into a unitary structure, over time and the regional concerns of smaller states will be masked by the national issues and demands of the Centre. Doubts are also being raised that 'One Nation, One Election' will exacerbate the trend of parliamentary elections becoming increasingly presidential and push our multi-party system towards a one-party state. Instead of expanding and deepening our democracy, it will narrow our democracy by straightjacketing the opportunity to vote. The concerns raised regarding synchronized elections are elaborated below:

(i) Logistical Issues

While proponents of the 'One Nation, One Election' proposal argue that simultaneous elections would reduce the overall expenditure, there are concerns that certain costs may, in fact, increase. A NITI Aayog paper supporting this proposal found that the central government would need to invest over Rs 9,300 crore to procure additional Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) and Voter Verifiable Paper Audit Trail (VVPAT) systems.¹¹⁵ Moreover, the requirement for extra security personnel and election officials to manage the larger-scale simultaneous elections could further escalate operational costs, raising questions about the financial feasibility of the initiative in its entirety.

The elections to the House of the People and State Assemblies are held using EVMs. Presently, same EVMs are used for elections in various States.

Therefore, conducting simultaneous elections necessitates procurement of more EVMs and also entails the problem regarding their storage. Due to the paucity of warehousing facilities, many states and UTs are compelled to store the EVMs in private buildings and educational institutions. There will be an increased demand for safe, practical storage facilities with increased number of EVMs. Increased number of EVMs will require more polling material, polling staff and additional vehicles. Ensuring smooth, peaceful and impartial polls also needs services of a significant number of polling officials from government organisations for significantly prolonged periods.

(ii) Constitutional and Legal Changes

Holding concurrent elections would require a series of amendments to the Constitution, in provisions governing timing of elections, tenure of legislatures, and electoral procedures. These constitutional amendments would require approval by a two-thirds majority in both houses of Parliament, as well as ratification by at least half of India's states. Modifications would also be required in the laws relating to elections like the Representation of the People Act, 1951, to align election schedules.

(iii) Potential Impact on Local Issues

Critics argue that with simultaneous elections national issues will dominate the discourse which may overshadow state-level concerns. The focus on state-specific challenges will be reduced leading to disconnect between voters' expectations and the outcomes of state elections. Opponents have also raised concerns regarding centralisation of power, giving the ruling party at the national level greater power over state politics.

(iv) Contradicts India's Diversity and Federal Structure

Opposition parties such as the Congress, the Left, and the Trinamool Congress have voiced their disapproval, arguing that 'One Nation, one Election' proposal weakens India's federal structure and could diminish the autonomy of state governments, giving the central government an upper hand in state matters.

Before implementing 'One Nation, One Election' rule, the government and Election Commission of India needs to build consensus which can be achieved through transparent dialogue, consultations, and deliberations among various stakeholders that include political parties, civil society and

citizens. Besides its benefits, there are issues which need to be adequately addressed before implementation which include:

- desirability to hold simultaneous elections,
- the pros and cons of synchronised elections,
- changes required in the constitutional and legal framework,
- practical preparations and investment needed in electoral infrastructure and technology,
- raising voter awareness about the advantages and challenges of simultaneous elections,
- potential impact on country's democratic processes.

The decision on its implementation should be a collective one, taking into account the intricacies involved and the variety of viewpoints being set forth. India's 'One Nation, One Election' policy should be well thought out, taking into account any potential effects on the democratic processes of the nation.

10. ADVANTAGES OF SIMULTANEOUS ELECTIONS

- Less expenditure so nation saves more.
- Political parties will make better policies than worrying for one elections or the other.
- The parity and the relationship between the citizens and their respective representatives shall become better given the securing of seats for another term.
- Grand scale elections help in job creation as large number of workers are required for the smooth conduct.
- Lesser damage to the public properties, no fake promises and proper utilization of resources can be done.
- The issues of locality, state and the municipalities are taken on the same lines as national issues.
- People can be aware as to whom they want to govern them because more often than not, the influence of media and other factors are such that people get swayed away by one particular ideology and then thinking that all the representatives belonging to a political party would function in the same manner. This can be prevented by having asolidified consolidated electoral process.

11. CRITISISM FOR SIMULTANEOUS ELECTIONS

- National parties will gain more power and regional parties will suffer.
- National issues may affect the election of state and local bodies
- As a practice, various governments tend to make plans for short periods than being far-sighted.
- The pre-existing governments will have to get their terms cut short and as a result, more tax shall be levied on the public.
- The process will ignore the smaller parties because the larger parties have lots of funds to contest.
- The coordination between the central and state governments will be hampered as the process of law making and enforcement cannot solely be delegated to the bureaucrats while the parties contest elections.
- The budget for the elections will have to be raised substantially

Cost of elections vs. Cost of democracy

- Holding simultaneous elections would not just ensure that the administrative machinery is allowed to engage in developmental activity, but also advantage the government treasury and save crores of rupees of taxpayers' money, by reducing the burden on security forces required for elections. It is estimated that the ECI spent over Rs. 4,000 cr on the 2019 elections.
- As an ONOE supporter ex-CEC Qureishi notes, the scale of police forces will be staggering: "Unless there is the deployment of an adequate number of paramilitary forces, even simultaneous elections will have to be carried out over a period of 2-3 months which will defeat the purpose. Currently, an election sees deployment of about 800 company forces. The government will have to provide at least 3,000-3,500 companies to ensure that the election is conducted within 30 days at least."
- There are also questions about the feasibility of simultaneous elections. The fact that polling is now electronic means that double the number of Electronic Voting Machines would be needed. Although the ECI in the 2019 elections has shown that logistical challenges can be figured out, the bigger problems raised by ONOE are conceptual and democratic challenges.

Federalism: The Ideology

- Recurrent elections may be good in a democracy as voters can ensure their voice is heard more frequently. Representatives are accountable and forced to interact with the voters more regularly during the term. Also, separate elections ensure that local and national issues don't

get mixed up because if combined, local issues that are of great importance are at risk of getting subsumed by bigger national ones.

- The underlying themes of national elections and state-level elections are different. While issues such as farmer crises, unemployment, and national security could play out big during Lok Sabha elections, assembly elections are usually won or lost on themes such as law and order, electricity, and deaths because of encephalitis or flooding.
- This principle is the core of federalism, which can be quite simply defined as a system of government in which several states form a unity but remain independent in internal affairs. India has a quasi-federal structure, and the Constitution establishes this when it calls India a “Union of States”, ONOE, therefore, can be seen as undermining the country’s federal system.

The Legal Limitations

- Article 83(2) deals with the tenure of the Lok Sabha and says that it shall be for 5 years unless dissolved earlier. Article 172 says that tenure of State Assemblies shall be 5 years unless dissolved earlier. The responsibility of the legislature is outlined in Article 75(3) that states “In a federal parliamentary democracy, the council of ministers in the Central government and the state government shall be collectively responsible, respectively, to the House of the people and to the Legislative Assembly [Article 164 (2)].
- However, the state assemblies can only be dissolved for specific reasons that are in accordance with Article 356 of the constitution, and dissolving the assembly for simultaneous elections would be a violation of the constitution.
- ONOE raises fundamental questions about governance: what would happen if the central government collapses in the middle of its tenure? Would elections be held in all the states again? Or would President’s Rule be imposed? Creating an amendment to the constitution for something of this magnitude would not only require many other situations and provisions to be taken into account but would also set an alarming precedent for more alterations to the constitution.

Article 83(2) and 172 of the Constitution stipulates that the tenure of Lok Sabha and State Assemblies respectively will last for five years unless dissolved earlier and there can be circumstances, as in Article 356, wherein assemblies can be dissolved earlier. Therefore, the ONOE plan raises serious questions. It will pose logistical challenges in terms of availability and security of electronic voting machines, personnel and other resources. EC may face difficulties in managing such a massive exercise. The idea of ONOE does not square with the concept of federalism as it is established on the notion that the entire nation is “one” contradicting the content of Article 1 which envisages India as a “Union of States. The Law Commission headed by Justice B. S. Chauhan reported that simultaneous elections are not feasible within the existing framework of the Constitution. It said that the Constitution, the Representation of the People Act 1951 and the Rules of

Procedure of Lok Sabha and State Assemblies would require appropriate amendments to conduct simultaneous polls. The commission also recommended receiving ratification from at least 50% of the States which may not be an easy task. The present form of recurrent elections can be seen as beneficial in a democracy as it allows voters to have their voices heard more frequently. As the underlying issues of national and State polls are different, the present framework prevents the blending of issues, ensuring greater accountability. A 2015 study by the IDFC Institute found “a 77% chance that the winning political party or alliance will win both the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections in that state when held simultaneously” . - undermining the distinctive demands and needs of each state. Various estimates by the Election Commission, NITI Aayog show that the costs of conducting all State and parliamentary elections in a fiveyear cycle work out to the equivalent of Rs. 10 per voter per year. The NITI Aayog report has also said that when elections are synchronized, it will cost the equivalent of Rs. 5 per voter per year. **In the short term, simultaneous elections will increase the costs of deploying far larger numbers of EVMs and VVPATs. So, amending the constitution to save Rs 5 for every voter in a year may not be a good idea.** There is economic research to suggest that such election spending by parties and candidates benefits the economy and the government’s tax revenues by boosting private consumption and serving as a stimulus. Building consensus among all political parties and states on the need and feasibility of simultaneous elections is the way ahead. This could be done through dialogue, consultation, and deliberation among various stakeholders. Investing in the infrastructure and technology required for conducting simultaneous elections, such as electronic voting machines (EVMs), voter-verified paper audit trail (VVPAT) machines, polling booths, security personnel, etc. **Aligning the electoral cycles of Lok Sabha and State Assemblies by either extending or curtailing their terms, as per a one-time constitutional amendment.**

Establishing a legal framework to deal with situations such as noconfidence motions, premature dissolution of assemblies, hung parliaments, etc., that may arise during simultaneous elections is also suggested. It can be held twice in a year so that if the assembly of any state is dissolved prematurely, the re-election can be conducted for that state in the next cycle. Creating awareness among the voters about the benefits and challenges of simultaneous elections, and ensuring that they exercise their franchise without confusion or inconvenience.

Even though simultaneous polls have their benefits, they have their own sets of problems. Critics have argued that holding simultaneous elections

dramatically shrinks the choices of the electorate (Kumar 2019). This could lead to 'national issues' getting importance over local ones, which would benefit the national parties over regional or local parties. Thus simultaneous elections would benefit larger national parties at the cost of regional parties in what would be a "national wave in favour of large national parties" (Debroy and Desai 2017: 20). This would weaken the federal democratic structure of the country and undermine the depth and breadth of Indian democracy.

The main counter argument of conducting simultaneous elections is the question of feasibility.

Simultaneous elections to Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies is difficult to implement due to the Constitutional arrangement. Neither the Lok Sabha nor the State Legislative Assemblies could be prematurely dissolved to synchronize General Elections to Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies (Parliament of India 2015). In such a case, the only possible option is to adjust the terms of many state assemblies, with either extension or curtailment of existing tenures, which is clearly undesirable. There is also a major operational challenge, considering logistics, security and manpower resource requirements, which makes it practically difficult to conduct elections at such a massive scale.

Another argument against the idea of simultaneous elections is that it could influence the voters' behaviour with many cases where voters have voted for the same parties to the State Assemblies and Lok Sabha when such elections did take place simultaneously. Such situations could lead to national issues influencing voting behaviour even in State Assembly elections. An analysis by IDFC Institute shows that on average, there is a 77% chance that the Indian voter will vote for the same party for both the State and Centre when elections are held simultaneously. On the other hand, frequent election cycles offer a measure of accountability as various local and state-level issues influence the elections from time to time.

12.SOLUTIONS: THE WAY FORWARD

Although the idea of simultaneous polls has the potential to have significant change in the Indian electoral system, it has its share of drawbacks. There are several serious statutory and constitutional amendments that need to be debated and discussed in this context. Any policy move in this regard would also require general consensus among stakeholders across the political spectrum, from political parties to the general public.

Moreover, there is also the question of long-term sustainability in case the ruling party or coalition government loses the majority in between terms, either in the Lok Sabha or state elections. In such a scenario, a two-cycle election process as suggested by the Parliamentary Standing Committee would serve a better purpose, where one phase could be in sync with that of the Lok Sabha elections and the other phase exactly 30 months after the first phase. Such an arrangement would definitely decrease the current frequency of elections in the country in the near term, thereby reducing the routine interruptions in the delivery of various welfare programmes.

Possible Solutions

The debate on **One Nation, One Election** revolves around striking a balance between governance efficiency, democratic principles, and federalism. While the idea presents administrative and economic benefits, concerns regarding state autonomy and democratic representation must be addressed. Below are some possible solutions to navigate these challenges:

1. Gradual Implementation Through Phased Elections

- Instead of an immediate nationwide transition, **phased synchronization** of elections can be implemented.
- Elections of **smaller groups of states** can be aligned with the Lok Sabha elections in phases, ensuring a smooth transition.
- A feasibility study and pilot projects can be conducted in select states before full implementation.

2. Constitutional and Legal Amendments

- Amendments to **Articles 83, 85, 172, 174, and 356** of the Constitution will be required to synchronize election terms.
- A **fixed term for legislatures** (barring exceptional circumstances) can be introduced to ensure election cycles remain consistent.

- Provisions should be made to prevent misuse of **Article 356 (President's Rule)** to dissolve state governments and enforce uniformity.

3. Strengthening Federalism and State Autonomy

- A **consensus-driven approach** involving state governments, political parties, and stakeholders should be adopted rather than imposing a unilateral decision.
- The **Inter-State Council** can be used as a platform to mediate between the Centre and states regarding concerns of regional autonomy.
- Special provisions can be introduced to **protect regional parties' interests**, ensuring they remain competitive in synchronized elections.

4. Alternative Models for Electoral Stability

- A **two-phase election model** can be explored, where half the country votes in one phase and the other half in another.
- The **Fixed Term Parliament Act (similar to the UK model)** can be studied to ensure stable governance while allowing mid-term elections under strict conditions.
- **Common electoral rolls and uniform voter lists** can be used for all elections to reduce redundancy and administrative burdens.

5. Addressing Governance and Political Stability

- To prevent frequent disruptions, the **no-confidence motion** should be accompanied by a **constructive vote of confidence** (where an alternative government must be proposed before dissolving the existing one).
- A framework should be developed to handle situations where a state government loses majority mid-term, ensuring political stability without necessitating re-elections.
- The Election Commission can set up a **special committee** to review electoral feasibility, monitor democratic impact, and propose policy adaptations.

6. Public and Political Consensus-Building

- A **national referendum or expert panel consultation** can be conducted to gather diverse opinions and ensure a democratic decision-making process.
- Political parties must be encouraged to **agree on a common roadmap**, ensuring that both national and regional concerns are addressed.
- Increased **awareness campaigns** on the benefits and challenges of simultaneous elections can help engage the public in informed discussions.

By adopting a **gradual, legally sound, and consensus-driven approach**, India can explore the feasibility of One Nation, One Election while **safeguarding federalism and democratic integrity**.

13. CONCLUSION

The concept of "One Nation, One Election" (ONOE) in India refers to the idea of synchronizing elections for the Lok Sabha (the national legislature) and all State Legislative Assemblies. It aims to streamline the election process, reduce costs and minimize the disruption of governance due to frequent elections. Key Points we discussed in this background guide on the Motion of "One Nation, One Election" :

1. Historical Context: India initially conducted simultaneous elections to the Lok Sabha and State Assemblies in 1951-52, 1957, 1962 and 1967. This practice was disrupted in the late 1960s due to the premature dissolution of some state assemblies and the Lok Sabha.

2. Objectives of ONOE
Cost Efficiency: Reduce the significant financial burden of conducting frequent elections.
Governance Continuity: Prevent frequent disruption of policy implementation due to the Model Code of Conduct.
Focus on Development: Shift focus from constant electioneering to governance and long-term planning.
Reduction in Electoral Fatigue: Reduce the recurring workload on election machinery and voter fatigue.

3. Advantages of ONOE
Economic Savings: Consolidated elections can save significant public expenditure.
Stable Governance: Governments can focus on long-term policy-making rather than short-term electoral gains.
Efficient Resource Use: Security forces, polling personnel, and logistical resources can be deployed more efficiently.
Increased Voter Turnout: Synchronizing elections may encourage higher participation due to reduced inconvenience.

4. Challenges and Criticisms
Constitutional Amendments Required: Major changes would be needed to Articles 83, 85, 172, 174 and 356 of the Constitution.
Practical Implementation: Addressing scenarios like the premature dissolution of a legislature.
Federal Concerns : May weaken the autonomy of states, as state and national issues could overlap during elections.
Complexity of Execution: Managing logistics and voting across such a large and diverse nation poses significant challenges.
Impact on Regional Parties: It could dilute the importance of state - specific issues, overshadowed by national narratives.

5. Alternatives to Address Frequent Elections
Phased Synchronization: Implement ONOE gradually by aligning the election cycles of some states with the Lok Sabha.
Fixed Terms: Introduce mechanisms to ensure legislatures complete their full terms unless in extreme cases.

6. Recent Developments: The Indian government has formed committees and engaged in debates to explore the feasibility of ONOE. This reflects growing political and public interest in the idea.

7. Way Forward: National consensus involving all political parties and stakeholders. Detailed study of the legal, logistical and administrative challenges. Pilot programs in selected regions or states to test the concept.

For Viksit Bharat governance based on the principles of democracy is paramount. Democracy can function only upon the faith of the people, which is built and regularly assessed through periodical elections to ascertain the popular will. In view of both long- and short term implications of the elections and manifestations for the future of democracy, there is a need to take a closer look at the process of administering elections in India and at the totality of the election process in a holistic manner. There are problems in the functioning of our electoral system that need to be rectified.

Frequent asynchronised elections causing disruption of the governance machinery, causing policy paralysis, and slowing down the pace of the developmental programmes is an area of concern. The government has approved the proposal to conduct synchronised elections across the country, aligning elections for the Lok Sabha, state assemblies, and local bodies under the “One Nation, One Election” plan. This, no doubt, will have significant benefits in terms of reducing costs, improving governance, and minimizing administrative disruption. However, to implement simultaneous elections, a delicate balance needs to be maintained between constitutional amendments, logistical preparedness, and preserving the federal spirit. To capitalize on the latent advantages of “One Nation, One Election,” the government needs to follow a consultative approach to address concerns associated with it to build a consensus approach.

A constitution has to be a 'living document' that is capable of adapting to changing needs and requirements of people and society. It has to be dynamic, effective, and efficient, responding to the changing situations and growing needs of the citizens and meeting their expectations. However, at the same time, the intrinsic values and basic features of the Constitution, such as democracy, free and fair elections, and federalism, cannot be compromised. In this background, we need to examine and implement the 'one nation, one election' rule; introducing reforms in the domain of the electoral system without damaging the intrinsic character and framework of the Constitution. No doubt it is not an easy task; there will always be people who will view the changes with doubt and oppose them, and want the status quo to be continued throughout.

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